



BEFORE

At the height of their power in the South, Republicans politically dominated the former Confederate states.

REPUBLICAN VOTERS

The **First Reconstruction Act of 1867 338-39** authorized the military to enroll eligible Black voters in the South. They registered 735,000 Black Americans, giving them a **majority over white voters** in five Southern states. The Republican Party was also supported by a minority of Southern whites who were "**Unionist**" in perspective, and was strongest in up-country areas where there were few large plantations.

REPUBLICAN ACHIEVEMENTS

Beyond granting **Black suffrage**, Republicans used their power to create new progressive state constitutions **338-39**. These documents legislated **universal voting rights** for men, expanded social services, and established public schools for white and Black people, at the cost of higher property taxes. In 1868 seven former Confederate states were **restored to the Union**, with the remainder brought back by 1870.

THE DEFEATED SOUTH

Southerners were **devastated by defeat** and unwilling to have further changes to their traditions imposed on them by the victorious North. They did not want to see former slaves, whom they considered socially inferior, as political equals. They also needed Black people to remain a **dependent workforce** in order to grow the cash crops on which the South depended: **cotton, tobacco, sugar, and rice**.

Life for many whites in the South was difficult during Reconstruction because the region was plagued by crop failures and poor market conditions. Even wealthy planters faced ruin and had trouble finding workers. Many Southerners also resented the meddling of Northern capitalists, occupying soldiers, and "carpetbaggers" —men who migrated South looking for economic opportunity or in support of social reform. In addition, many white Southerners regarded the imposition of Federal control under the rule of Radical Republicans as corruption, and vowed to "redeem," or recover, the governments of their states.